

The island stays.

The village goes.

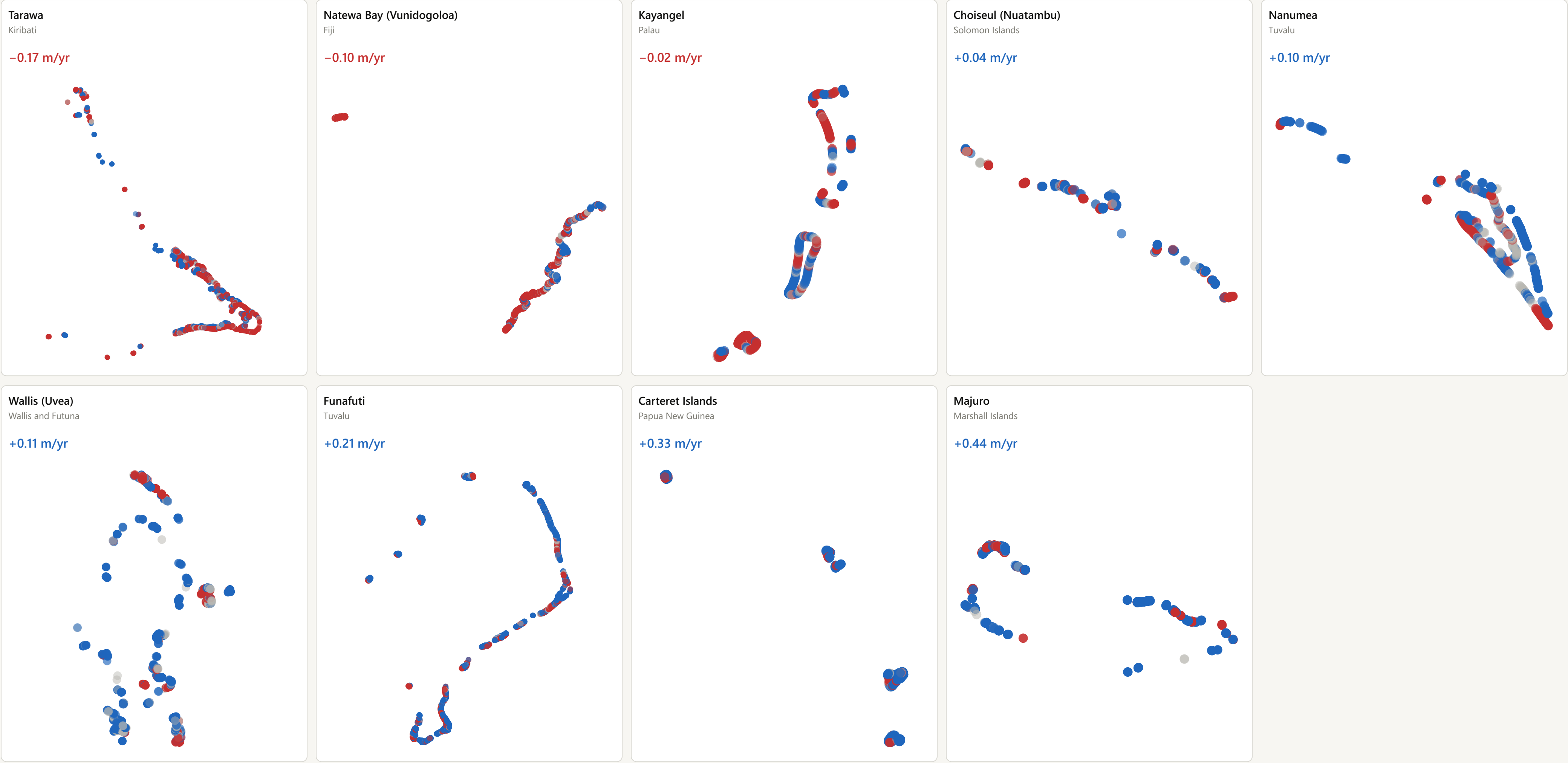
“The Pacific is sinking” is one sentence stretched over thousands of islands that are doing opposite things. Twenty-five years of satellite shoreline measurement, read island by island, says the sentence is wrong in both directions — and that it is measuring the wrong thing.

5 islands gone Kakatina, Kale, Rapita, Rehana and Zollies no longer exist.	+0.33 m/yr Carteret Islands — gaining land while ~1,700 people are relocated.	+0.21 m/yr Funafuti — the emblem of a drowning nation, advancing.	−0.17 m/yr Tarawa — named in the same breath, moving the other way.
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Nine islands. Nine different answers.

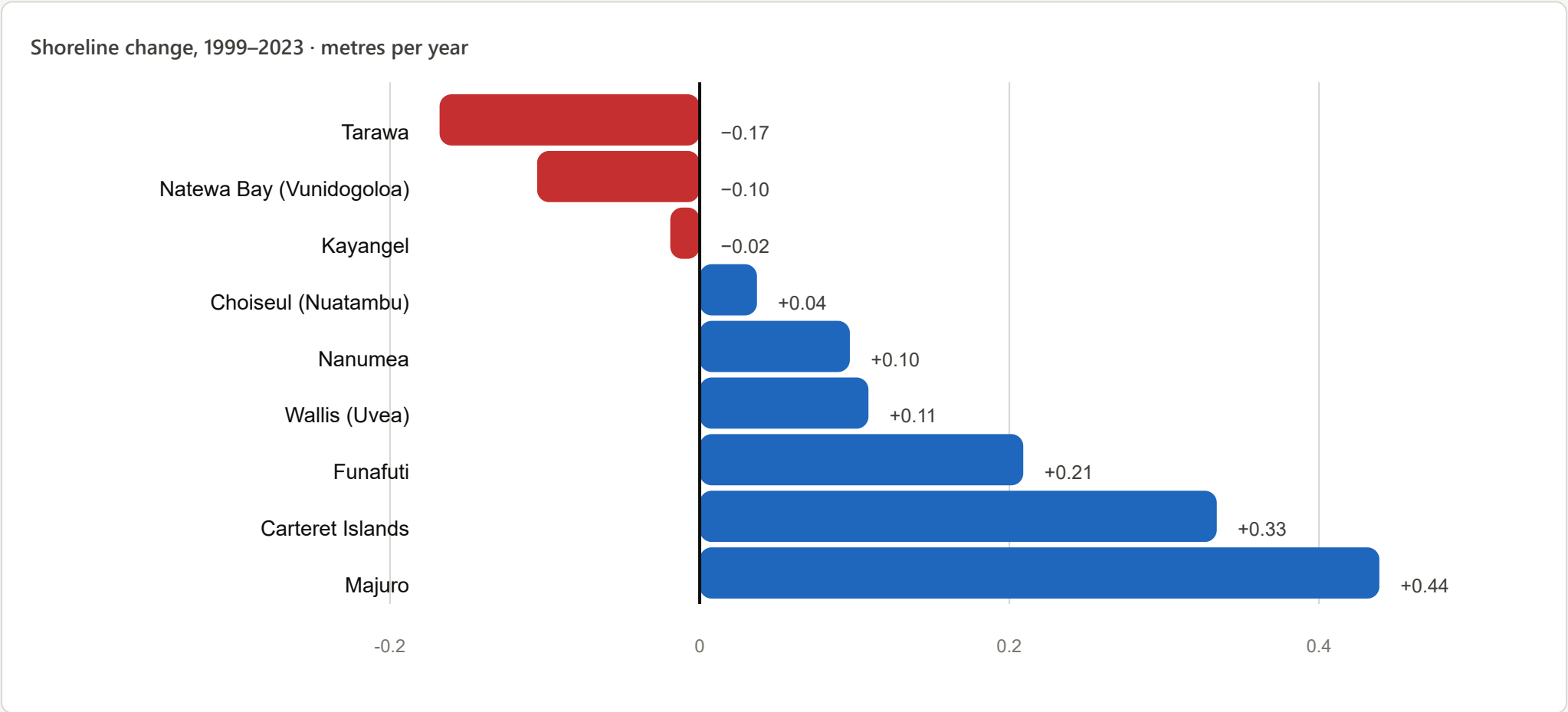
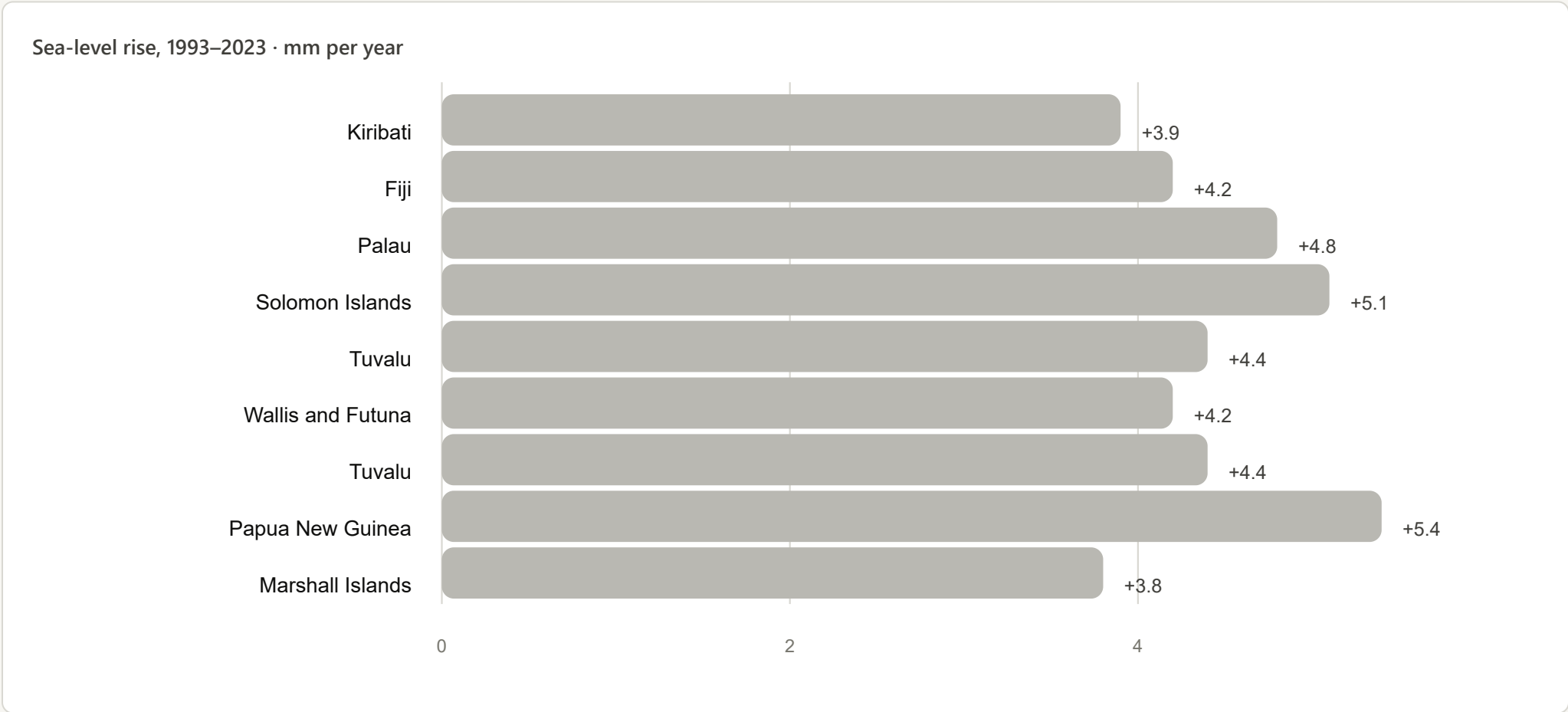
Every dot is one satellite measurement transect, drawn at its true position — together they trace the coastline. Red is losing land, blue is gaining it.

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The same ocean. Nine different answers.

Sea level is rising at every site and the ocean is warmer at all of them — that forcing is regional and near-uniform. The shoreline response is not, and it is not predicted by how fast the sea is rising (Pearson $r = +0.13$, $p = 0.74$). Rows are in the same order in both charts: if sea level decided the outcome, the right chart would echo the left. It does not.



Land is not the same measurement as home.

CHOISEUL · SOLOMON ISLANDS

Five islands are already gone.

Kakatina, Kale, Rapita, Rehana and Zollies — vegetated reef islands of up to five hectares — no longer exist. On Nuatambu, home to 25 families, eleven houses have washed into the sea since 2011 and over half the habitable land has gone. Taro is planning to become the first provincial capital on earth to relocate.

CARTERET ISLANDS · PAPUA NEW GUINEA

Its people are leaving land that is growing.

Around 1,700 Carteret Islanders are being moved to Bougainville by Tulele Peisa, with 350 families targeted by 2027. The shoreline here is advancing at +0.33 metres a year. They are not leaving because the island shrank. They are leaving because the wells turned salty and the gardens stopped growing.

VUNIDOGOLOA · FIJI

Moved two kilometres inland, 2014.

The first village in Fiji relocated for climate change. About 140 people left 26 houses on the foreshore for 33 new homes on higher ground, at a cost near FJ\$1 million. More than 80 other Fijian communities have since been identified as at risk.

Sea level is rising under all of us. What it costs is decided locally — by the reef, the sediment, the storms, and where we were able to build. Adaptation planned on a regional average will protect the wrong coast. **Ask which island. Then ask who lives there.**